

INTRODUCTION



This Guide is designed to help members of a neighborhood respond more swiftly and responsibly to a community-wide disaster within their own neighborhood.

The Guide outlines a general **Neighborhood Emergency Preparedness Plan** that each neighborhood can then adapt to its own needs. Each plan in each neighborhood would have these main components:

Neighbors become better acquainted with members of their neighborhood, build bonds of collective responsibility, and share expertise and resources pertinent to a disaster response.

Neighbors agree on specific, tangible action steps they will take in response to an emergency, so that they can confidently and immediately respond to situations until professional disaster response teams arrive on the scene.

Neighbors revisit their plan at least once each year to determine if revisions are necessary and to make sure volunteers are in place for all job descriptions. By working together, neighbors can also be better prepared for more localized emergencies while waiting on emergency services.

This Guide provides the essential steps to accomplish the above goals so that any neighborhood — regardless of capacity or resources — can put a plan in place.

This Guide is not intended to serve as a formal training manual for disaster response or to overshadow the necessity for family-level preparedness. Neighborhood-level emergency preparedness fills a niche in community wide disaster response. It promotes the urgency for citizens to equip themselves with knowledge and skills in order to help their neighbors in case of a disaster event in which emergency response personnel cannot immediately access their neighborhood.

This Guide was created by the City of Knoxville's Office of Neighborhood Empowerment and the Knoxville - Knox County Emergency Management Agency (KEMA), with assistance from the Knoxville Police and Fire Departments, Knox County Health Department, and American Red Cross.

PREPARE YOUR HOUSEHOLD

A neighborhood cannot be prepared unless individual households are prepared. Think about it: If you are not prepared personally, you will be focused on your family's needs and less likely to lend a hand to your neighbors. The same goes for the family next door.

Help others by first being prepared to help yourself. Follow these steps:

Create a **Household Ready Kit** that contains survival essentials for at least 72 hours. Items such as flashlights, batteries, water and non-perishable food can be stored in one or more plastic tote boxes. These then can be used to “shelter in place” at home—or easily and quickly moved to your vehicle in the event an evacuation is necessary.

Assemble all emergency contact phone numbers for family members (work, school, cell, etc.), as well as for local emergency management agencies. Keep a copy in the emergency kit.

Familiarize yourself with your home utilities and know how to shut them off if the units become hazardous. *(Utilize professionals to turn gas back on!)*

Review and update emergency plans with family members routinely, especially with children.

Consider whether obtaining personal disaster preparation training, such as CPR, Stop the Bleed, CERT, or fire safety, is right for you



GET TO KNOW YOUR NEIGHBORS

Neighborhood Watch — crime prevention at the block level — is most successful when neighbors know each other and feel comfortable checking on one another and making inquiries if something is amiss.

The same is true for neighborhood-level emergency preparedness. Strong bonds among neighbors empower them to take care of each other until first responders can reach the neighborhood.



GET TO KNOW YOUR NEIGHBORS

LAY THE GROUNDWORK FOR YOUR NEIGHBORHOOD EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS PLAN BY FOLLOWING THESE STEPS:

1

Get to know your neighbors.



2

Host a potluck dinner or other social event so that neighbors can become acquainted. This does not happen overnight, but trust usually develops over time.

3

Work with two or three other neighbors. Plan, publicize and host a neighborhood meeting to discuss setting up a preparedness network. Like neighborhood watch, this works best with groups of 10 to 40 homes. A neighborhood organization in a large neighborhood may wish to divide the neighborhood into target areas of 10 to 40 homes with a block captain in each area. The number of households in each target area is up to you, your neighbors and your neighborhood organization. Just keep it manageable. If you need assistance organizing your neighbors for a neighborhood meeting, please contact the *City of Knoxville, Office of Neighborhood Empowerment*.

4

At this first meeting, explain the importance of having a neighborhood-level disaster plan and determine if there is support for setting one up. Elect an organizing committee to develop a Neighborhood Emergency Preparedness Plan to bring back to the group for approval.

5

Continue to provide opportunities for neighbors to introduce themselves and become well acquainted with one another.



CREATE A NEIGHBORHOOD PLAN

WHILE SOCIAL BONDS ARE CRITICAL TO YOUR SUCCESS, CREATING A PLAN OF ACTION PUTS THE ICING ON THE CAKE.

WITH THE KNOWLEDGE AND PARTICIPATION OF THE RESIDENTS IN THE TARGET AREA, YOUR ORGANIZING COMMITTEE CAN FOLLOW THESE STEPS TO CREATE YOUR OWN NEIGHBORHOOD EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS PLAN:



Obtain a map of your neighborhood (in PDF format) from the Office of Neighborhood Empowerment. This map should show house numbers. Use this map in your planning activities. You could also use KGIS: <https://www.kgis.org/maps/Neighborhoods>



Survey the area within a 1-3 mile radius of your neighborhood to identify potential sources of industrial hazards — such as railways, interstate highways, and chemical plants — and research how to respond should a disastrous incident occur. *For assistance with surveying or researching response strategies, contact Knoxville – Knox County Emergency Management Agency (KEMA).*



Discuss the most likely natural hazards that affect the Knoxville area — such as straight line winds and ice storms — and likely impacts, such as downed power lines. What are the likely needs? How will your neighborhood respond?



Designate a **Neighborhood Gathering Site**, where able neighbors can gather immediately after a disaster. This serves as a meeting point and an action center for deploying emergency response teams. This can be a front porch, open garage or other visible, easily accessible and covered space.



Designate a **Neighborhood Care Site** inside someone's home or a community building to which you have access. *This is a location where children and people with special needs can be cared for, if necessary, after a disaster. Recognize that it may be best for individuals to “shelter in place” with neighborhood support.*



Make a list of neighbors who are willing to share specialized skills such as CPR, First Aid, plumbing, communications (Ham radio), ability to shut off natural gas or operate a chain saw.



CREATE A NEIGHBORHOOD PLAN

- ➡ Create a list of neighbors who have essential equipment or supplies such as ladders, chain saws, walkie-talkie, generators, and 4-wheel drive vehicles. *It is NOT necessary for your neighbors to have fancy equipment or life-saving skills to create a successful Neighborhood Emergency Preparedness Plan. These things help, of course. But what matters most is your willingness to rely on one another — and your preparedness as a neighborhood.*
- ➡ Decide which forms of communication you will use, such as a phone tree, Family Service Radios, physical reporting to a designated person, window signage, and door-to-door visits. Think ahead: For example, what will you do if cell phone service is spotty or non-existent?
- ➡ A key form of communication is signage that can be placed in the front window of each home. Consider raising funds to have a local printer create 11x17 signs on sturdy corrugated cardboard stock or similar material. Or each household can make their own sign. One side of the sign says “OK” and the other side says “HELP.” Each household can post this sign so that your neighborhood response team knows where to stop.
- ➡ Create a neighborhood directory with occupants, addresses, and as much contact information as each person feels comfortable giving out. This directory might be provided to each household in the directory, along with the neighborhood map. It might also be helpful to include neighbors’ unique skills. (e.g. Laura is a nurse/Drew is a veterinarian/Jim does HVAC work)
- ➡ Provide a secure and confidential way that each household might share pertinent information — such as health issues, people with mobility limitations or other special needs — with a few key leaders. *If a neighbor is not comfortable sharing their personal details, that is fine. However, you may wish to encourage your neighbors to make sure that at least one of their trusted neighbors is aware of any special needs. During a disaster, it may be lifesaving for someone nearby to be aware of the neighbor’s critical needs or limitations.*



CREATE A NEIGHBORHOOD PLAN



Name a **Neighborhood Emergency Action Team** that includes those with special skills and equipment, as well as individuals with specific job descriptions such as those mentioned in the next section. Recruit volunteers — and backup volunteers — for each job description on your team.



Agree on the specific steps your leaders and residents will take in the event of an emergency.



It is important that the **Neighborhood Emergency Action Team** has an understanding of how to assist people with special needs and disabilities.



You may wish to ask the Office of Neighborhood Empowerment and/or KEMA to review your plan and make suggestions.



Put your draft plan in writing and then take it back to a meeting of all residents in your target area for their feedback and approval.



Once the plan is approved, continue to strengthen it.

- For example: You may wish to hold a “Walk and Meet” event, where neighbors gather at one end of the street or target area and walk from house to house. Each household introduces themselves with whatever detail they wish.
- Encourage one another to seek CPR, First Aid, **Community Emergency Response Training (CERT)** and other training to make sure your neighborhood has the skills it needs.
- Invite guest speakers from various emergency services to speak at your meetings.
- Conduct a drill periodically. Work with the Office of Neighborhood Empowerment to involve emergency services in a test of your plan. *This can be a fun way to bring neighbors together. Follow the drill with a potluck dinner and invite your local firehall to join in!*

IMPLEMENT THE PLAN



Your **Neighborhood Emergency Action Team** is responsible for implementing this plan in the event of a widespread emergency in which First Responders are unable to reach your neighborhood right away.

Step One

The first priority is to take care of yourself and your loved ones, and to secure your home.

Step Two

Place a HELP or OK sign in your front house window to alert your neighbors about your status. The HELP and OK cards are meant for communication among neighbors. Individuals may feel the necessity to call 911 on their own, and this is their right.

Step Three

If you are able to do so, report to your assigned neighborhood gathering site or neighborhood care site.

Step Four

At the gathering site, the Neighborhood Emergency Coordinator works with others to assess the extent of the emergency and makes sure key neighborhood personnel (or their backups) are in place. The Neighborhood Liaison begins communicating with Emergency Services.

Step Five

Door-to-door scout teams (whose members should be known in advance of any emergency) are deployed. Via the Neighborhood Liaison, they notify Emergency Services of life-threatening situations and other priority needs. After each team has completed their duties, they report back to the neighborhood gathering site.

Step Six

Continue to exchange pertinent information and make further decisions as necessary. For example, neighbors who are proficient with chain saws may begin clearing downed trees that are blocking streets and that are not touching power lines. Others might rope off downed power lines. Specific tasks will depend on the particulars of the emergency at hand.

Step Seven

When professional Emergency Services arrive on the scene, stand aside and provide support as requested.

NEIGHBORHOOD EMERGENCY ACTION TEAM: JOB DESCRIPTIONS

Neighborhood Emergency Coordinator: Ideally this should be a single person who works collaboratively with others but who is nevertheless in charge of implementing the plan, receiving reports from others, coordinating communications, and supervising the overall effort.

Neighborhood Liaison: To avoid confusion and miscommunication, a single point person in the neighborhood should be designated to communicate with Emergency Services. He or she will report damages and pinpoint the most urgent personal needs in the neighborhood. This person also relays updates provided by Emergency Services back to the Neighborhood Action Team.

Radio Relay: This person listens to the **Emergency Alert System** or to a NOAA Weather Radio and relays pertinent information to the group. If the Neighborhood Action Team has instituted Family Service Radios as its line of communication, this person serves as the information aggregate for the neighborhood.

Neighborhood Scout Team: This group walks door-to-door in the neighborhood, searching for distressed households with HELP cards in windows and households with no signs at all. This group checks on elderly or special needs neighbors; if appropriate, they assist in moving these individuals to the neighborhood care center. They may be prepared to perform first aid and to check for gas leaks or structural damage. The group will utilize the neighborhood map accordingly, checking off houses that have been serviced. *There may be more than one scout team, depending on the size of the target area and the number of volunteers.*

Other job descriptions may come to mind as you develop your plan, and you may wish to modify the descriptions listed here.



POTENTIAL EMERGENCIES IN KNOXVILLE

HERE ARE A FEW THINGS THAT KEMA HAS LISTED AS POTENTIAL EMERGENCIES IN THE KNOXVILLE AREA:

SEVERE WEATHER

Spring and Summer

- Severe Storms
- Tornadoes
- Wind
- Flooding
- Hail
- Extreme Heat

Winter

- Freezing Temperatures
- Ice Storms
- Snow
- Blizzards

Fires

Earthquakes

WIDESPREAD ILLNESS

Covid-19

Flu – H1N1, Bird Flu

Food or Water Contamination

WIDESPREAD UTILITY OUTAGES

- Electric
- Water
- Gas (stores, gas stations, banks, ATMs may be closed)

Closed Roads/Bridges

Airplane Crashes

Trail Derailments

Large Accidents on Interstate

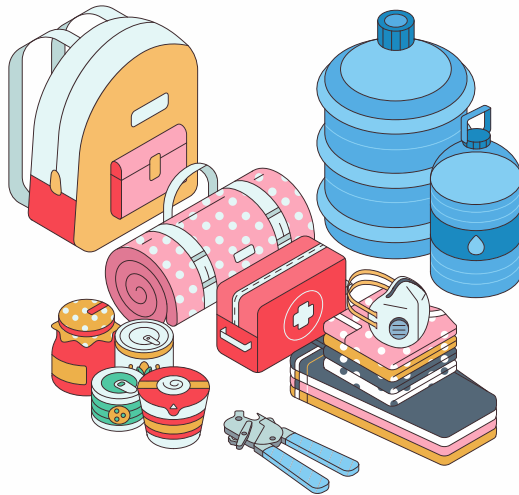
Terrorism

Hazardous Chemicals or Materials



HOUSEHOLD READY KIT

THE FOLLOWING ITEMS COULD BE INCLUDED IN YOUR HOUSEHOLD READY KIT:



- WATER SUPPLY FOR 3 DAYS (3 GALLONS FOR EACH PERSON)
- FOOD (3 DAY SUPPLY OF NON-PERISHABLE ITEMS)
- MANUAL CAN OPENER
- PRESCRIPTION MEDICATIONS
- CASH AND COINS
- FM RADIO AND BATTERIES
- WEATHER RADIO AND BATTERIES
- FLASHLIGHT AND BATTERIES
- BATTERY OR SOLAR CELL PHONE CHARGER
- INFANT ITEMS – DIAPERS, FORMULA, BOTTLES
- ITEMS FOR THE ELDERLY – HEARING AID, WALKER, CANE, ETC.
- FIRST AID KIT
- GLASSES, CONTACTS, SOLUTION
- COPIES OF IMPORTANT DOCUMENTS – INSURANCE CARDS, WILLS, BIRTH CERTIFICATES, IDS
- TOOLS – WRENCH, PLIERS, MULTI-TOOL
- WATERPROOF MATCHES
- PLATES, CUPS, UTENSILS
- ZIP-LOCK BAGS AND TRASH BAGS
- PET ITEMS – FOOD, WATER, CARRIER/CRATE
- CHLORINE BLEACH AND MEDICINE DROPPER
- FEMININE PRODUCTS
- HYGIENE ITEMS – SOAP, SHAMPOO, TOOTH BRUSH, TOOTH PASTE, DEODORANT
- PAPER AND PENCIL/PEN
- EMERGENCY REFERENCE BOOKS
- CHILDREN’S ITEMS – COLORING BOOKS, GAMES, PUZZLES, STUFFED ANIMALS
- CHANGE OF CLOTHES/SHOES – FOR HOT AND COLD WEATHER
- BLANKETS/SLEEPING BAGS/PILLOWS

GOOD SAMARITAN LAW



BY STATE LAW, CITIZENS WHO IN GOOD FAITH RENDER EMERGENCY CARE AT THE SCENE OF AN ACCIDENT, MEDICAL EMERGENCY OR DISASTER CANNOT BE HELD LIABLE BY THE VICTIM OR THE VICTIM'S FAMILY IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG, EXCEPT IN CASES OF GROSS NEGLIGENCE. HERE IS THE RELEVANT PORTION OF THE LAW (EMPHASIS ADDED):

TENNESSEE CODE ANNOTATED 63-6-218: "GOOD SAMARITAN LAW"

(A) THIS SECTION SHALL BE KNOWN AND CITED AS THE "GOOD SAMARITAN LAW."

(B) ANY PERSON, INCLUDING THOSE LICENSED TO PRACTICE MEDICINE AND SURGERY AND INCLUDING ANY PERSON LICENSED OR CERTIFIED TO RENDER SERVICE ANCILLARY THERETO, OR ANY MEMBER OF A VOLUNTEER FIRST AID, RESCUE OR EMERGENCY SQUAD THAT PROVIDES EMERGENCY PUBLIC FIRST AID AND RESCUE SERVICES, SHALL NOT BE LIABLE TO VICTIMS OR PERSONS RECEIVING EMERGENCY CARE FOR ANY CIVIL DAMAGES AS A RESULT OF ANY ACT OR OMISSION BY SUCH PERSON IN RENDERING THE EMERGENCY CARE OR AS A RESULT OF ANY ACT OR FAILURE TO ACT TO PROVIDE OR ARRANGE FOR FURTHER MEDICAL TREATMENT OR CARE FOR THE INJURED PERSON, EXCEPT SUCH DAMAGES AS MAY RESULT FROM THE GROSS NEGLIGENCE OF THE PERSON RENDERING SUCH EMERGENCY CARE, WHO IN GOOD FAITH:

(1) RENDERS EMERGENCY CARE AT THE SCENE OF AN ACCIDENT, MEDICAL EMERGENCY AND/OR DISASTER, WHILE EN ROUTE FROM SUCH SCENE TO A MEDICAL FACILITY AND WHILE ASSISTING MEDICAL PERSONNEL AT THE RECEIVING MEDICAL FACILITY, INCLUDING USE OF AN AUTOMATED EXTERNAL DEFIBRILLATOR, TO THE VICTIM OR VICTIMS THEREOF WITHOUT MAKING ANY DIRECT CHARGE FOR THE EMERGENCY CARE; OR

(2) PARTICIPATES OR ASSISTS IN RENDERING EMERGENCY CARE, INCLUDING USE OF AN AUTOMATED EXTERNAL DEFIBRILLATOR, TO PERSONS ATTENDING OR PARTICIPATING IN PERFORMANCES, EXHIBITIONS, BANQUETS, SPORTING EVENTS, RELIGIOUS OR OTHER GATHERINGS OPEN TO THE GENERAL PUBLIC, WITH OR WITHOUT AN ADMISSION CHARGE, WHETHER OR NOT SUCH EMERGENCY CARE IS MADE AVAILABLE AS A SERVICE, PLANNED IN ADVANCE BY THE PROMOTER OF THE EVENT AND/OR ANY OTHER PERSON OR ASSOCIATION.

DEFINITION OF GROSS NEGLIGENCE

GROSS NEGLIGENCE REFERS TO AN ACT TAKEN WITHOUT EXERCISING EVEN THE MOST BASIC AMOUNT OF CARE OWED TO OTHERS. SUCH AN ACT INVOLVES A DELIBERATE DISREGARD FOR THE SAFETY OR WELLBEING OF ANOTHER PERSON. GROSS NEGLIGENCE DOES NOT REFER TO ACTS UNDERTAKEN WITH INTENT TO HARM ANOTHER, BUT ACTS FOR WHICH THE PERPETRATOR KNEW, OR SHOULD HAVE KNOWN, WOULD RESULT IN INJURY OR DAMAGES TO ANOTHER PERSON.

GLOSSARY OF TERMS



Community Emergency Response Training (CERT) – one of five federal programs promoted under the umbrella organization Citizen Corps, CERT is an organization of volunteer emergency workers who have received specific training in basic disaster response skills, and who agree to supplement existing emergency responders in the event of a major disaster.

Emergency Alert System – The Emergency Alert System (EAS) is a national public warning system that requires radio and TV broadcasters, cable TV, wireless cable systems, satellite and wireline operators to provide the President with capability to address the American people within 10 minutes during a national emergency.

Family Service Radios – walkie-talkies that are powered by the Family Radio Service (FRS) which is a private, two-way, very short-distance voice and data communications service for facilitating family and group activities. This personal radio service does not suffer the interference effects found on citizens' band (CB) also used by cordless phones, toys, and baby monitors.

Household Ready Kit – simply a collection of basic items your household may need in the event of an emergency. Emergency management agencies suggest assembling a kit of essentials that will last you 72 hours.

Neighborhood Care Site – a location where children and people with special needs can be cared for, if necessary, after a disaster. This could be inside someone's home or a community building to which you have access.

Neighborhood Emergency Action Team – includes those with special skills and equipment, as well as individuals with specific job descriptions.

Neighborhood Emergency Coordinator – a single person who works collaboratively with others but who is nevertheless in charge of implementing the plan, receiving reports from others, coordinating communications, and supervising the overall effort.

GLOSSARY OF TERMS



CONTINUED

Neighborhood Emergency Preparedness Plan – a plan of action designed by your neighborhood to respond quickly and safely in the event of an emergency. The NEPP is meant to be designed to fit your specific neighborhood.

Neighborhood Gathering Site – a location where able neighbors can gather immediately after a disaster. This serves as a meeting point and an action center for the Neighborhood Emergency Action Team. This can be a front porch, open garage or other visible, easily accessible and covered space.

Neighborhood Liaison – a single point person in the neighborhood should be designated to communicate with Emergency Services. He or she will report damages and pinpoint the most urgent personal needs in the neighborhood. This person also relays updates provided by Emergency Services back to the Neighborhood Action Team.

Neighborhood Scout Team – a group that walks door-to-door in the neighborhood, searching for distressed households with HELP cards in windows and households with no signs at all. This group checks on elderly or special needs neighbors; if appropriate, they assist in moving these individuals to the neighborhood care center. They may be prepared to perform first aid and to check for gas leaks or structural damage. The group will utilize the neighborhood map accordingly, checking off houses that have been serviced.

Preparedness Network – a network of communication amongst neighbors that is similar to Neighborhood Watch. Like neighborhood watch, this works best with groups of 10 to 40 homes but the size is ultimately up to each individual neighborhood.

Radio Relay – an individual tasked with listening to the Emergency Alert System or to a NOAA Weather Radio and relaying pertinent information to the group. If the Neighborhood Action Team has instituted Family Service Radios as its line of communication, this person serves as the information aggregate for the neighborhood.

Voluntary Organizations Active in Disaster – a coalition of the major voluntary organizations in the area that have made disaster-related work a priority. VOAD member agencies provide skilled direct services along the continuum from disaster prevention and preparation to response, recovery, and mitigation.



IMPORTANT PHONE NUMBERS

Police/Fire/Medical Emergency	911
City of Knoxville Information	311
Tennessee 211	211
Knoxville Police Department Non-Emergency Line	865-215-4010
Knox County Sheriff's Office	865-215-2243
UT Police Department	865-974-3114
Knoxville Fire Department	865-595-4480
Knox County Rescue Squad	865-546-4852
Knoxville Utility Board	865-524-2911
Knox County Health Department	865-215-5000
Knoxville-Knox County Emergency Management Agency	865-215-1166
Tennessee Emergency Management Agency	615-741-0001

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES



American Red Cross of East Tennessee <http://www.redcross.org/tn/knoxville>

CDC.gov Healthy Pets <https://www.cdc.gov/healthy-pets/emergency-preparedness/index.html>

disABILITY Resource Center <http://www.drctn.org/>

East Tennessee Voluntary Organizations Active in Disasters (VOAD)
<https://www.tnvoad.org/east-tn-voad/>

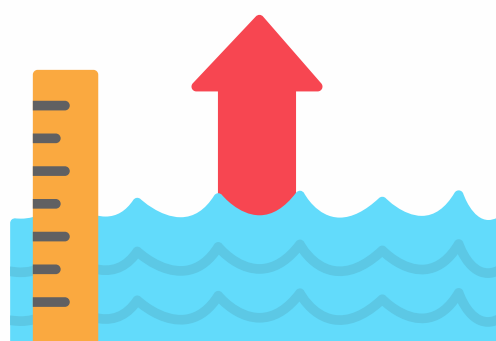
Emergency Alert System <https://www.fema.gov/emergency-alert-system>

Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA) <https://www.fema.gov/>

Knox County Association of Baptists - Disaster Relief
<https://www.kcab.org/disaster-relief>

Knox County Health Department <http://www.knoxcounty.org/health/>

Knoxville-Knox County Emergency Management Agency (KEMA)
https://www.knoxvilletn.gov/government/city_departments_offices/knoxville-knox_co_emergency_management_agency



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

CONTINUED



Knoxville Fire Department

https://www.knoxvilletn.gov/government/city_departments_offices/fire_department

Knoxville Local Emergency Planning Committee (LEPC)

<https://www.knoxvilletn.gov/cms/One.aspx?portalId=109562&pageId=16057281>

Knoxville Police Department <https://knoxvilletnpolice.gov/>

Prepare UTK Emergency Management <https://prepare.utk.edu/be-ready>

Office of Neighborhood Empowerment

https://www.knoxvilletn.gov/government/city_departments_offices/neighborhoods

Ready.gov <https://www.ready.gov/>

Ready.gov Prepare Your Pets <https://www.ready.gov/pets>

Tennessee Department of Environment and Conservation (TDEC)

<http://www.tn.gov/environment/>

Tennessee Emergency Management Agency (TEMA) <http://www.tnema.org/>

